

Seashells

The shells that wash up on beaches are the empty homes of soft-bodied sea animals called molluscs. Shells come in amazing shapes and colours. Some have two joined halves, others are in one piece, often a coil or a spiral. No two, even of the same type, are ever identical.

WHO NEEDS A SHELL?

Molluscs have easily damaged bodies and are too slow moving to hurry away from danger. A rigid shell provides a safe place to retreat into or close up tightly when predators are around. Empty shells make useful shelters for other animals.

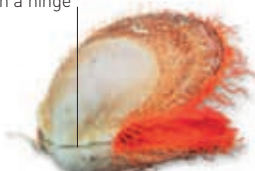
THERE ARE MORE THAN 50,000 KNOWN SPECIES OF MOLLUSCS



LIMPET

Tucked beneath its shell, a limpet clinging tightly to a rock is very difficult to dislodge.

Two parts open on a hinge



FLAME SCALLOP

It is hard for a predator to open a scallop shell once the hinged halves are firmly shut.

Snail's large foot emerges



COMMON WHELK

Like its land-based cousins, this sea snail pulls itself into its shell to escape danger.



HERMIT CRAB

This soft-bellied crab makes its home in discarded sea snail shells.



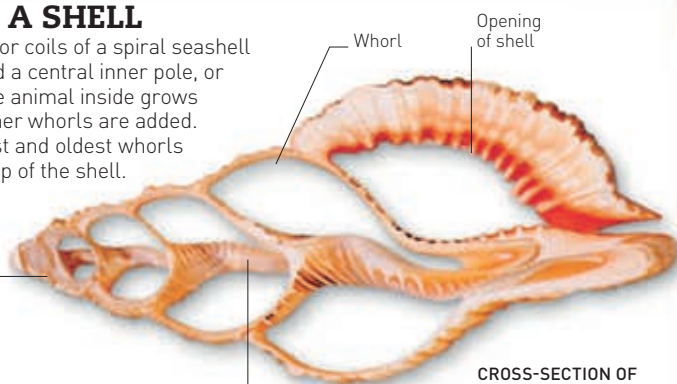
SHORE CRAB

Crabs regularly shed their own shells. Until a new one hardens, a "borrowed" scallop shell can provide protection.

INSIDE A SHELL

The whorls or coils of a spiral seashell form around a central inner pole, or pillar. As the animal inside grows bigger, further whorls are added. The smallest and oldest whorls are at the top of the shell.

Oldest whorls



Central pole

Opening of shell

CROSS-SECTION OF A SPIRAL SHELL

SIZE COMPARISON

The biggest molluscs on Earth are the giant clams, which can weigh as much as 227 kg (500 lb). The smallest shells belong to some minute sea snails, several of which would fit on a thumbnail.



LARGEST SHELL: GIANT CLAM
1.2 m (4 ft)



SMALLEST SHELL: SEA SNAIL
1 mm (0.04 in)

HINGED SHELLS

Many sea animals – such as clams, scallops, and oysters – are bivalves. Their shells are divided into two parts called valves that are joined by a hinge. The animal opens the shell to feed and closes it to take refuge.



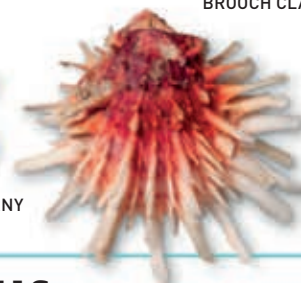
CHICKEN VENUS



AUSTRALIAN BROOCH CLAM



GIANT RAZOR SHELL



PACIFIC THORNY OYSTER



PEARL OYSTER

SNAIL SHELLS

The largest group of seashells are those of the sea snails. These are endlessly varied in size, shape, and pattern. There are species that twist like corkscrews, while others coil or look like caps or shiny eggs. The animals that live in these shells creep slowly about on a large fleshy foot.



COMMON EGG COWRIE



HUMPBACK COWRIE



EYED COWRIE



HONEY COWRIE



TROSCHEL'S MUREX



SCARLET CONE



TEXTILE CONE



TRITON'S TRUMPET



SPOTTED TUN



MAPLE LEAF TRITON



ROBIN REDBREAST TRITON